



New Red Alga

A team of marine biologists from UK and China have discovered a new species of seaweed. <https://dgit.in/jun20-19>



The future of Kickstarter

Kickstarter CEO Aziz Hasan talks about the future of the crowdfunding company. <https://dgit.in/jun20-20>

FEATURE

vast majority of smartphones shy away from this level of innovation.

Additionally, it is also taking far too long for issues in smartphones such as the eyesore 'notch' to disappear. The pop-up camera was a step in the right direction and was displaying some real innovativeness. However, manufacturers, such as OnePlus, have seemed to steer away from it this year, despite using it in the past, and have opted for the safer punchhole cut out instead of working on improving the pop-up function and the module's resilience. The name of the game in the premium smartphone market is simply hiking up the specs (as well as the prices) year after year and calling the current-gen specs the new 'cutting edge'. By 2020, we would have expected smartphones to completely change their form factor. They could have possibly become smaller, even chip-sized and could perform all functions by using gesture inputs and by projecting holographic pictures and videos. Or they could even have been flexible wristbands with bendable OLED panels and flexible innards. While we have seen concept phones from Lenovo that resemble this and Samsung even unveiled their flexible display, these are nowhere close to being mass manufactured.

HYPERLOOP

Since Elon Musk published his outlandish 'Hyperloop Alpha' white paper in 2013 highlighting a network full of 'pods' which would shuttle passengers at near-supersonic speeds (1,200kmph) over long distances, several companies began heralding it as the next evolution in travel and began developing the futuristic transit. These companies then assumed that Hyperloop would possibly be operational within a few years to a decade. However, it seems that the idea is far from fruition and could be decades away. Currently, in tests conducted in a 500 meter tube, the maximum speed achieved was 387 kmph, which seems measly compared to the estimates in 2013. In 2018, Musk's Boring Company completed an underground testing tunnel which was unveiled in mid-December. However, the ambitions that Musk set out with were severely scaled back.

Instead of a large pod, the attendants at this test were made to climb into electric Tesla cars which shuttled them along the path at a lowly 40 mph. Musk attributed this disparity in speed to a faulty paving machine. He clarified that the future system would allow for speeds up to 150 mph. Nevertheless, some companies did manage to hit speeds of 250 mph and higher in the recent years in some Hyperloop competitions. In the 2019 edition of the SpaceX Hyperloop Pod Competition, the winner's pod hit a top speed of 463 km/h in a 1.2 km vacuum tube near the SpaceX headquarters in California. It also exploded shortly after reaching this speed... It is safe to say that the day when Hyperloop takes over the world as the new mode of fast transportation is probably decades away.



AUGMENTED REALITY

While AR has been integrated into our daily lives in the form of Snapchat and Instagram filters, and even games such as Pokémon Go, it hasn't achieved widespread adoption as expected. The technology seemed to be extremely promising when it first began appearing since it opened up the door to many possibilities. Users could maybe walk around an unknown city and could be pointed out details about nearby restaurants, hotels, tourist attractions and more, all of which would be overlayed onto the real world, making it a very immersive and seamless experience. However, what we got was a much tamer version of these possibilities. It is also quite appalling to see that AR hasn't seen much adoption in the industry of corrective glasses. In the US, 75 percent of people wear some form of corrective lenses, so adding AR capabilities to already existing wearables should

have been a no-brainer. The deterring factor was that AR technology made the glasses bulky. Companies and researchers are now working towards AR contact lenses, we hope that the technology sees mass adoption if the AR contact lenses work as they are meant to.

CRYPTOCURRENCIES

Cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin and Ethereum were considered as the future of digital payments, however, this promising decentralised technology never really saw widespread adoption. The last decade saw plenty of highs and lows for cryptocurrencies with Bitcoin rates especially fluctuating constantly. The volatility of cryptocurrencies was a major deterrent standing in the way of mass adoption. Additionally, cryptocurrency scams also run rampant which spook potential customers even further. Also, with over 2,000 different cryptocurrencies out there, making sense of the market can be a nightmare.

WIRELESS CHARGING

The biggest disappointment of wireless charging technology is that it is simply not wireless! They still have to be plugged to an outlet and are probably bulkier than normal chargers due to the wireless pad or stand. Additionally, they are often slower than standard wired chargers. With most wired chargers now coming with Fast Charging capabilities that can top up a phone in as less as an hour, it seems impractical to plonk your device on a 5 or 10 watt charger and wait for the battery to slowly refill. The ones with faster charging capabilities tend to get uncomfortably hot while charging. The biggest disappointment is having to align your phone perfectly on to the charger. If your phone is ever so slightly off centre, the charging stops since the coils in the charger and the phone need to align perfectly. This is certainly not what people envisioned when they thought of wireless charging. We certainly didn't envision replacing the struggle to insert the Type-C or even worse, micro-USB cable into the phone's port with the struggle of aligning our phone perfectly to the wireless coil inside wireless chargers!